Reconstruction in the North Carolina Piedmont

Reconstruction (1865-mid to late 1870s) was a time of great change and violence for the Southern States in the United States of America. Into this chaos, millions of formerly enslaved people tried to create freedom and new lives out of emancipation. They enjoyed newly won political, social, and economic freedoms across the South, but were met with hate and violence by many in the white community who sought to reestablish white supremacist rule. Despite the violence, freed Black people formed social and political organizations and carved out bits of freedom and life out of a hostile system.

As many authors have shown, understanding Black participation in Reconstruction is critical to understanding Reconstruction as a whole. It is also crucial to understand their labor as it shifted from enslaved labor to free wage labor, which radically transformed the Southern economy and the United States, and was a site of great conflict over the meaning of freedom. Black Reconstruction historiography started with *Black Reconstruction,* by W.E.B. Du Bois, who argued that Black people actively fought for their rights and shaped politics, but the United States government failed to enforce the 14th and 15th amendment and social equality due to a counter-revolution led by white capitalists and the psychological benefit of whiteness that turned the white working class against the Black working class.[1] However, many early-20th-century white historians ignored Du Bois's work. More recent scholars, such as Steven Hahn, further argued that freedpeople actively shaped and formed politics during Reconstruction. He focused on rural freedmen as the driving force behind Black political and social participation. They

[1] W. E. Burghart Du Bois, *Black Reconstruction: An Essay Toward A History of the Part Which Black Folk Played in the Attempt to Reconstruct Democracy in America, 1860-1880* (New York: Russell & Russell, 1935).

formed Union Leagues, biracial coalitions, and church organizations to fight for their rights as free people. However, white violence forced freed people out of politics and repressed them. Though repressed in formal politics, freed people's social networks remained and formed the basis for everyday resistance during Jim Crow.[2] Tera Hunter highlighted how women, not just men, worked to create freedom out of emancipation, expanding the male-dominated field of study. She focuses on how Black women actively fought to protect, enjoy, and define their freedom in Atlanta, Georgia.[3]

These more nationally focused histories often overlook North Carolina's history, only briefly mentioning Klan violence and its suppression in the state. Some historians, such as Nelson and Hahn, briefly focus on this region, but only on the "Kirk-Holden War," when North Carolina's government suppressed Ku Klux Klan (the Klan) violence and reestablished civil order in Alamance and Caswell counties in 1870. The focus on white supremacist violence has limited our understanding of Black life and labor in this time.[4] Furthermore, a large portion of the state, the Piedmont region, is missing from the historiography, other than the Klan violence and its suppression.[5] Several books, such as Deborah Beckel's *Radical Reform* and Sharon Ann Holt's *Making Freedom Pay,* looked beyond Klan violence in North Carolina and expanded our

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[2] Steven Hahn, *A Nation Under Our Feet: Black Political Struggles in the Rural South From Slavery to the Great Migration* (Cambridge: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2003).

[3] Tera W. Hunter, *To 'Joy My Freedom: Southern Black Women's Lives and Labors After The Civil War* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1997)examines the political history of North Carolina and the state's interracial activism and politics, primarily in.

[4] Scott Reynolds Nelson, *Iron Confederacy: Southern Railways, Klan Violence, and Reconstruction* (Chapel Hill, University of North Carolina Press, 1999); Scott Reybolds Nelson, "Red Strings and Half Brothers: Civil Wars in Alamance County, North Carolina" in *Enemies of The Country: New Perspectives on Unionists in The Civil War South,* ed. John C. Inscoe, Robert C. Kenzer (Athens, University of Georgia Press, 2001); Hahn, *A Nation Under Our Feet.*

[5] The Piedmont region of North Carolina is the middle region of the state in between the Appalachian Mountains to the west and the Coastal Plains to the east. It consists of the counties in between Wake and Cleveland Counties. https://www.ncpedia.org/geography/region/piedmont

understanding of the state during Reconstruction.[6] *Radical Reform* focuses on the political history of North Carolina and the interracial activism and politics of the state, primarily focusing on the eastern part of the state and Raleigh. Fusionists, Black Republicans, and poor white voters worked together to lead an interracial coalition to overturn Democratic rule in the 1890s and temporarily establish a more democratic government.[7] Holt's *Making Freedom Pay* focuses on the rural population and the efforts of Freed people to gain land ownership and self-reliance in Granville County, North Carolina. There, freedpeople used their household economy to build small amounts of capital and leveraged the Southern credit system to gain small tracts of land and independence from wage labor.[8] *Making Freedom Pay* provides an example of how to study social history in North Carolina during this period.[9] Their research points to a greater need to study this period in North Carolina's history to better understand the nuances of Reconstruction, the effect of Klan violence on the freed Black population, and the transition from enslaved to free wage labor.

While not focused on Reconstruction, Keri Petersen's research on Enslaved labor on the North Carolina Railroad provides context for the shift from enslaved labor to free wage labor in North Carolina. Her research highlights the hiring out of enslaved men to work on the NCRR.[10] Her work helps fill the gap in labor historiography in North Carolina and provides a model of how to research labor history related to Black labor on the railroads of North Carolina.

My research builds on the methods of Beckel and Holt by investigating Klan violence across the Piedmont, not just limited to the two counties where the state government suppressed

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[6] Deborah Beckel, Radical Reform: Interracial Politics in Post-Emancipation North Carolina (Charlottesville, University of Virginia Press, 2011); Sharon Ann Holt, *Making Freedom Pay: North Carolina Freedpeople Working For Themselves 1865-1900* (Athens, University of Georgia Press, 2000).
[7] Beckel, *Radical Reform*.
[8] Holt, *Making Freedom Pay*.
[9] Hunter, *To 'Joy My Freedom;* Du Bois, *Black Reconstruction.*
[10] Keri Petersen, "The North Carolina Railroad, industrial slavery, and the economic development of North Carolina" (PhD Diss., The University of North Carolina at Greensboro, 2017).

the Klan. This will expand our understanding of Klan violence during Reconstruction in North Carolina beyond the "Kirk-Holden War." To broaden our knowledge even further, I explore Black labor along the North Carolina Railroad (NCRR) after 1870 to better understand the transition from enslaved labor to Black free wage labor and the effect of Klan violence. This provides a unique perspective that continues Petersen's work on enslaved labor on the NCRR.[11] These two approaches help fill the North Carolina-sized gap in Reconstruction history.

Klan violence in North Carolina, as throughout the South, suppressed Black organizing and social life. The state government, however, only focused its actions against the Klan in Alamance and Caswell Counties. Instead of defending Black organizing and labor, this suppression of the Klan led to the Conservative Party, the name of the Democratic Party in North Carolina during Reconstruction, retaking control of the State Government and the impeachment of Governor William W. Holden, thus allowing the reestablishment of white supremacist rule across the state. This left the Black community at the mercy of white supremacist rule. Nevertheless, Black people carved out bits of freedom from this hostile system. Therefore, this paper argues that despite the widespread Klan violence in North Carolina, Black railroad workers were able to carve out bits of freedom through their cash wages in order to survive a white supremacist system. The cash wages gave Black families capital in a cash-poor South that allowed them to send their children to school and for wives to choose to work for themselves and their families instead of for white people. By investigating Black free wage labor along the railroad in North Carolina, we gain a clearer understanding of how freed Black people, during Reconstruction, leveraged their economic position to carve out means of survival and self-determination.

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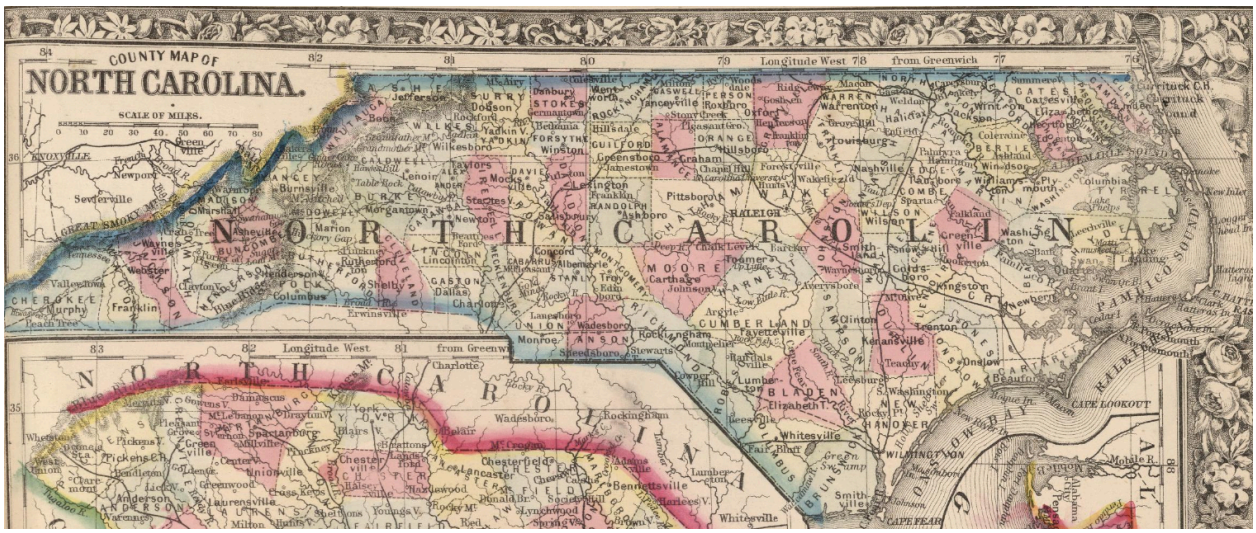
[11] Petersen, "The North Carolina Railroad, industrial slavery, and the economic development of North Carolina."

White Supremacist Violence Across the North Carolina Piedmont

Freed Black people organized across the Piedmont region of North Carolina. They created political, social, and educational organizations to protect and enjoy their rights. However, the Klan, just like in other states, sought to undermine Black people's organizing, rights, and the rule of law to reestablish white supremacist rule over the state. They intimidated, coerced, stole from, whipped, and lynched Black people and white Republicans to achieve this goal. But with two high-profile murders in Alamance and Caswell Counties, the state government moved to suppress the Klan.



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Freed people across the South organized politically to protect their newly won rights and promote the Republican Party. To do this, they created Union Leagues, which were political organizations that supported Black voting rights, civil rights, and organized locally for the Republican Party.[13] Alamance County, situated east of Guilford County and Greensboro, and

[12] "County map of North Carolina. Map of South Carolina. County map of Florida," in *David Rumsey Historical Map Collection,* by Samuel Augustus Mitchell Jr. (Philadelphia: S.A. Mitchell Jr. 1865), https://www.davidrumsey.com/luna/servlet/detail/RUMSEY~8~1~235356~5510448:County-map-of-North-Carolina--Map-o.

[13] Hahn, *Nation Under Our Feet,* 174-175, 186-187*;* Nelson, *Iron Confederacies,* 100-104.

West of Orange County and Durham, was no different. There, freedpeople organized the Loyal Republican League. The League had special initiations and rituals and organized and promoted freedmen voting for the Republican Party. It also served as a support and organizing group for the many Black railroad workers in Company Shops (present-day Burlington, North Carolina).[14] Beyond political organizing, the North Carolina Railroad Company paid workers in cash wages, providing them more economic stability than many white people in Alamance.[15] These factors enabled freed Black people to establish the foundation of a strong Black community in Alamance County. Wyatt Outlaw, a multiracial, formerly enslaved man, was at the center of this community. He worked as a wagon repairman and operated an eating saloon out of his house, which was a community hub for the railroad workers and the Black community.[16] He was one of the leaders of the Alamance Union League, was elected town commissioner, and was appointed as a deputy member of the Grand State Council. This allowed Outlaw to organize police forces in Alamance County and further empowered the Black community.[17]

Outlaw was not unique in his political organizing; Robert Fitzgerald was one of the leaders of the Black community in Orange County, one county east of Alamance County. He lived in Hillsborough and worked as a schoolteacher and political leader in the late 1860s and early 1870s. Fitzgerald helped organize mass meetings and voting for the Republican Party in Hillsborough.[18] Through these organizations and communities, Black people actively fought for and protected their newly won rights.

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[14] Nelson, *Iron Confederacies,* 100-104.
[15] Nelson, *Iron Confederacies,* 100-104; North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records*, Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[16] Scott Reynolds Nelson, "Red Strings and Half Brothers: Civil Wars in Alamance County, North Carolina, 1861-1871," in *Enemies of The County: New Perspectives on Unionists in The Civil War South*, Ed. John C. Inscoe, Robert C. Kenzer (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2001), 44-45
[17] Nelson, *Iron Confederacies*, 112
[18] Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers* #4177, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.

Freed Black people also organized churches and other social organizations alongside Union Leagues to build community and provide support for each other. In Salisbury, halfway between Charlotte and Greensboro, Black people organized politically and socially in a Union League. In December 1868, they wrote to the governor reporting on one of their meetings. They held their meeting at the Dixonville Church, a local Black church. They were organizing and collecting money to buy a graveyard for the Black community.[19] Many Black communities across North Carolina organized Union Leagues and Churches as social and political organizations that provided community support and political action.

Beyond the Union leagues and direct political organizing, Black people also organized schools to teach literacy to their children and other adults to further improve their political and economic status. In Orange County, freed Black people organized schools. Fitzgerald helped build a church and a school in Hillsborough that served the local Black community.[20] These teachers often required support from the government, Freedmen's Bureau, and/or Northern Charities to teach their students.[21] For instance, two teachers, Ann Lane from Moore County, and R. F. Hoppen from Fayetteville, wrote to Governor Holden requesting financial support to teach their Black students.[22] As many of their students were impoverished, few of them could afford to pay for school, and so teachers required support from the government and charities to survive.[23]

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[19] Freedmen of Salisbury to William W. Holden, 5 December 1868, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 214, Folder December 1-7, 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[20] Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers* #4177, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
[21] Ann Lane to William W. Holden, 26 January 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 215, Folder January 26-31, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina; R F Hoppen to William W. Holden, 24 May 1869, in G*overnors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 218, Folder May 20-24, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina; Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers* #4177, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
[22] Ann Lane to William W. Holden, 26 January 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 215, Folder January 26-31, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina; R F Hoppen to William W. Holden, 24 May 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 218, Folder May 20-24, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina.
[23] American Missionary Society, "North Carolina Ministers and Teacher," in *the Guy Benton Johnson Papers #3826,* Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.

Writing to the governor was a common occurrence during Reconstruction. Many citizens wrote to the governor requesting help, pardons, and reporting occurrences in their county. Churches and Schools allowed Black people to organize socially and politically, thus protecting and enjoying their freedom. These institutions provided more than education and religious services; they also operated as meeting and organizing spaces for the Republican Party, further laying the groundwork for Black people's political engagement.

Another organization that was very important to the Black community was the Freedmen Bureau. It was a federal agency that worked to support Black people by organizing schools, reporting outrages, and helping unite families right after the war.[24] The reporting of outrages gave Black people, many of whom were illiterate, a voice in the historical record as white Freedmen's Bureau officers recorded their stories and reported them to the federal and state government. The agency operated in North Carolina until the late 1860s and was the primary tool of federal support for freedpeople during Reconstruction.[25] Black people used it as another tool to protect their freedom and access to the government. However, many whites saw the growing political access and power of Black people as a threat to the white supremacist order of the United States and targeted Black people and white allies with harsh violence.

Many white people, led by the old planter elite and the Conservative Party, attempted to regain control of the state through politically and racially motivated violence. White planter elites led the Conservative Party, built the party on a white supremacist platform, and had close ties to the Klan. They wanted to destroy and prevent Black organizing and enjoyment of newly won freedoms and rights, and undermine the rule of law to make the Republican Party unable to rule the state.

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[24] "Freedmen's Bureau Records - North Carolina" in *Freedmen's Bureau Records Online: Records of the Bureau of Refugees, Freedmen, and Abandoned Lands.* https://www.freedmensbureau.com/northcarolina/index.htm.
[25] Ibid.

The organization of the Klan was very decentralized and can be more described as a phenomenon and less of a single organization.[26] The many groups that were called the Klan or claimed to be the Klan, while decentralized, were united in their goal of reestablishing white supremacist rule and their violent methods. These organizations used threats, marches, whippings/beatings, and murders to reestablish white supremacist rule over the Southern States. Each branch operated independently of the other and acted on a local scale to undermine the rule of law and break Black and Republican political power.[27] They wore disguises to look like demons and ghosts of dead Confederate soldiers to hide their identity and further intimidate Black people.[28] Through their racially and politically motivated violence, they successfully undermined the rule of law in many states across the South, and led to a government crackdown that, while successful in suppressing the Klan, could not save the already damaged Republican governments and Black political organizations, leading to Democrats and white supremacists retaking control of Southern government in the 1870s.[29]

Across the Piedmont, the Klan attempted to interfere with elections and stop the Black population, who were overwhelmingly Republican, from using their right to vote. For instance, in a town called Warrenton, north-west of Raleigh and Durham, one citizen, Wm (William) Bauthers, wrote to Governor Holden about white people meeting secretly at night for several nights in October 1868. Beyond their secret meeting, boxes "have been received in this place containing sixteen shooters."[30] He feared that the white population was planning to disrupt "the day of speaking … thereby to defeat the Republicans on Tuesday," the day of the election.[31] He

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[26] Nelson, *Iron Confederacies*, 5.
[27] Ibid. 97-98.
[28] Ibid. 111.
[29] Ibid. 98.
[30] Wm Baulhus to William W. Holden, 31 October 1868, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* box 212-213, folder October 19-23, 1868*,* State Archives of North Carolina.
[31] Ibid.

requested military protection for the Black community from Governor Holden.[32] Like other people across the state, Bauther wrote to the governor in hopes of getting help with local issues. At this time, it was very common for people to write to the governor for help, as the government was very responsive to requests by citizens. Furthermore, Bauther's letter highlights the Klan's use of violence to target Black voting and political organizing. The Klan used threats, intimidation, and violence to attempt to suppress the Black vote and thus the Republican vote to reinstate Conservative rule across the state.

Even in counties where people did not report election violence to the governor, the Klan and Conservatives still threatened violence over the election and Black people voting for the Republican Party. In Orange County, Fitzgerald led many freed Black men to vote for the Republican ticket in the 1868 election, which resulted in a Republican victory for Governor William W. Holden. Holden was liked by the Black community and quite radical as he had pushed for Black voting rights and political participation in North Carolina during the early years of Reconstruction.[33] In response to the election, one white man said that it was "the [B]lack man's day" but threatened that "tomorrow will be the white man's," hinting at the presence and coming Klan violence centering around elections and voting rights in the county and the Piedmont as a whole.[34]

Election violence did not end with the election of 1868; instead, the Klan continued to punish Black people for voting throughout the following year. In the fall of 1869, the Klan whipped Carter Cassey, a Black man from Alamance County. They, just like the others, attacked

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[32] Ibid.
[33] Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers #4177*, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
[34] Ibid.

him at night and "badly whipped" him.[35] The Klan said they whipped him because they were "going around and whip [sic] all the old radicals, and we know you are one."[36] The Klan targeted Black people for organizing politically and using their right to vote. The Klan sought to intimidate and terrorize the Black community so that they would no longer vote for the Republican Party, and so that the Klan could reestablish white supremacist rule over the state.

Klan violence also had a gendered element. They attacked both men and women as a means of emasculating men by proving that Black men could not protect their families, thus reinforcing white supremacy over Black families. Orange County, because of the Black organizing and community building, was also a hotbed of Klan violence. In one instance of Klan-related violence in Durham, there was an attack on Jessie Garrett, a freedman, and his family. Jessie Garrett, a Black man from Durham, married a white woman, whose name is not mentioned in the Freedmen's Bureau document. This led to outrage among the local white population, who, during the summer of 1868, burnt down their house. The Klan violence displaced the Garretts and forced them to live in a schoolhouse for the next few days until the Klan, dressed in their robes, attacked the family again in the middle of the night. Garrett fled into the woods while the Klan harassed his wife and children. The Klan threatened to "burn up everything" again and told Garrett's wife to flee with her children.[37] Soon after the family fled from Durham, escaping to Greensboro "without anything," where they reported the crimes to the Freedmen's Bureau.[38] The family feared that "their lives were in danger," and would not go back to Durham.[39] By targeting families, the Klan sought to break the power of Black men. The Klan

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[35] *61 Citizens Terrorized by the Ku Klux: In & Around Alamance County, North Carolina, 1868-1870 as Told in Their Own Words in The Official Transcript of the Impeachment Trial of Governor William W. Holden,* Ed. Alex Albright. (Alamance R. A. Fountain, 2022) 62.
[36] Ibid., 63.
[37] Freedmen's Bureau to William W. Holden, 7 August 1868, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 213, Folder August 1-7, 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[38] Ibid.
[39] Ibid.

emasculated them as they proved white dominance over Black men and their inability to protect their families. This served a political end as it cemented a white supremacist social order over Black men and women.

In a case of gendered violence in Alamance County in the fall of 1869, the Klan attacked Andrew Shoffner, a Black man, and his wife. The Klan, just as they had done with many other freedpeople, broke into Schoffner's house in the middle of the night, took him outside, and brutally whipped him.[40] They gave him "about fifty licks" and whipped his wife another "twenty or thirty" times.[41] They attacked him and his wife because he had "voted for the radical ticket."[42] The Klan sought to punish him for voting for the Republican Party. Furthermore, the targeting of his wife also brought in a gendered element of Klan violence. The Klan attacked women to prove that Black men did not have the power to protect Black women.[43] They emasculated the men to further cement white supremacist power over Black people.

Direct violence was not the only tool used by white planters and the ruling class to control the black community. In the Summer of 1868, in Company Shops, white employers used their power over employment to control the Black population, their labor, and political opinions. "Freedpeople are persecuted without mercy by their former masters, who threaten to discharge from employment all laborers who differ from [their employers] in their political opinion,"[44] wrote one Freedmen's Bureau officer. The employers leveraged their position of controlling who could work for them to attempt to control the Black population and stop them from voting for the Republican ticket. This was another form of control and power that the white ruling class used to

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[40] *61 Citizens Terrorized by the Ku Klux*, 52-55.
[41] Ibid., 53-54.
[42] Ibid., 54.
[43] Hannah Rosén, *Terror in the Heart of Freedom: Citizenship, Sexual Violence, and the Meaning of Race in the Postemancipation South* (Chapel Hill: The University of North Carolina Press, 2009), 180, 181-182.
[44] Freedmen's Bureau to William W. Holden, 20 August 1868, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* box 212, Folder August 19-21, 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.

attempt to reestablish white supremacist rule. By controlling who could be employed and threatening freedpeople's jobs, the white ruling class hoped to stop Black political organizing in the county.

The Klan, the Conservative Party, and members of the white community also targeted Black citizens with harassment, threats, and violence as a means of making the state ungovernable by Republicans and to stop Black people from enjoying their social and political rights. In Caswell County, North of Alamance County and south of Danville, Virginia, the Conservative Party and Klan organized and incited violence against Black and white Republicans. In the Summer of 1868, the Conservative Party had a meeting in Yancyville, where they claimed that Reconstruction was unconstitutional and led to the very severe beating of a Republican named Jim Graves.[45] A few days later, one of the white men, named Nat L. Johnson, who had attacked Graves, attacked a colored man named Elizha Swepson, striking him with "several blows across the head." When Swepson fought back, Johnson "drew a pistol and shot Swepson … wounding him severely."[46] While Johnson was arrested and taken before a Black magistrate named John E. Book, the Klan came to the town to stop the court case.[47] Most of the white citizens armed themselves and threatened the Black population and white Republicans, including state senator John W. Stephens. The case continued, but Stephens was able to defuse the white fear by pledging on his life that the Black population would behave appropriately.[48] While this defused the situation for a time in Yancyville, white violence against Black people continued across the county. The Klan violence was intended to disrupt the rule of law and civil authority, thus making the county impossible to govern for the Republican Party.

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[45] John W Stephens to William W. Holden, 29 August 1868, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 212-213, folder August 25-31, 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[46] Ibid.
[47] Ibid.
[48] Ibid.

The Klan terrorized and whipped many Black and white Republicans to suppress Black organizing and agency. In one such case in Alamance County, the Klan attacked a Black man named Joseph Harvey during the winter of 1868. They broke into his house, kidnapped him, and put a rope around his neck. They pulled him up several times, choking him. They let him down and then proceeded to brutally whip him.[49] Beyond that, they attacked his wife, striking her across the head "with one of the clubs they had with them."[50] While the attackers did not tell Harvey why they beat him and his wife, he was part of the Union League.[51] The Klan sought to break the Union League by targeting and beating its members. By doing this, they hoped to make it so that Black people would be too afraid to join the organization and to vote for the Republican Party, thus cementing white supremacist rule over the state. Furthermore, their lawless behavior and the inability of local governments to hold them accountable undermined the rule of law, making the county impossible to govern by the Republican Party.

The Klan harassed, stole from, and murdered Black and white citizens of North Carolina. Because of their violence and intimidation, they made it impossible for the local civil authority to enforce the rule of law. By early 1869, the Klan in Chatham County was around 200 strong, according to O.A. Williams, a Justice of the Peace.[52] He requested help from the state government to deal with the rampant Klan violence. The Klan had harassed "the respectable citizens" of Chatham County and refused to "live under Republican government."[53] They, like other branches of the Klan, traveled at night in disguises and attacked both Black and white Republicans. In one case of violence, the Klan attacked a man and his wife, dragging "the man

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[49] *61 Citizens Terrorized by Ku Klux:* 20-24.
[50] Ibid., 22.rampant
[51] Ibid., 24.
[52] O. A. Williams to William W. Holden, 23 January 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* box 215, Folder January 16-25, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina.
[53] Ibid.

off in the dark."[54] The source does not tell of the fate of the man or woman, but it can be assumed, because of the political and racial nature of Klan violence across North Carolina and the South, that the Klan beat and/or killed him for his political opinions and race. Again, this highlights the Klan's desire to snuff out any Black organizing for the Republican Party. Their request for support also shows how the Klan undermined local authority, making Republicans unable to govern the county and protect its Black citizens effectively.

Local authorities often were unable to protect freed Black people due to rampant Klan violence. In Goldsboro, situated halfway between Raleigh and New Bern, a group of citizens reported on "an organized gang of white persons" in early 1869.[55] This gang reportedly murdered five freed Black men as well as "repeated complaints… of outrages" made against the freed Black population, such as the theft of Charles S. Slar's horse.[56] The Klan stole another horse on the eighteenth of February 1869 from a Freedman named Lewis Britt.[57] The local authorities were apathetic and did not help nor protect the Freed people from white violence. The group of citizens requested military protection or supplies to arm themselves to "suppress the outrages, punish the perpetrators, and offer adequate protection to the lives and property of inoffensive law abiding citizens."[58] This shows how the Klan violence completely undermined the rule of law and made it so that local authorities could not adequately deal with the violence. Despite requests for help, white violence continued in and around Goldsboro. White men, in the fall of 1869, killed a colored man and attacked another who was coming from school, "beat[ing] him

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[54] Ibid.
[55] Sam Sin to Willaim W. Holden, Governors papers February 18 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 216, Folder February 16-23, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina.
[56] Ibid.
[57] Gaw W. Himlas to William W. Holden, Governors Papers February 20 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 216, Folder February 16-23, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina.
[58] Sam Sin to Willaim W. Holden, Governors papers February 18 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 216, Folder February 16-23, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina.

helpless."[59] These beatings and killings terrified the Black population and made them fear for their lives if they went to school.[60] The request for aid from the state government and the continued violence across the county showed the failure of the local civil authorities to protect freed Black people.

The Klan not only targeted Black citizens but also government and military officials to disrupt the rule of law. In more instances of Klan violence in Orange County, the Klan attacked and murdered two colored soldiers and wounded their officer in April 1869.[61] The Klan also killed a Black man in Hillsborough in the fall of 1869. They "marched or paraded in Chapel Hill," to further intimidate the Black community in Orange County.[62] In another instance of white violence, a white man "drew a huge knife on a black man and dared him to attempt to defend himself."[63] And in December of 1869, the Klan killed another Blackman in Hillsborough .[64] These events highlight the commonality and variety of Klan violence and intimidation. The Klan would beat and kill Black people, march in the streets, and intimidate as a show of force. They did all this to break the Black community and political organizing, undermine the rule of law, and reestablish white supremacy in North Carolina and across the South.

In December of the same year, the Klan remained active in Caswell County. They attacked a Black man named Jacob Brunnock in his home. The Klan, in their disguises, took him out of his bed and "beat him so that he will not be able to do any more work this winter if ever."[65] "[H]e was beat [sic] because he was a republican" and had upset a white man named

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[59] H. F. Stevens Jr. to William W. Holden, Governor's Paper October 25 1869, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 221, Folder October 16-31, 1869, State Archives of North Carolina.
[60] Ibid.
[61] Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers #4177*, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
[62] Ibid.
[63] Ibid.
[64] Ibid.
[65] C S F Samaway to William W. Holden, 28 December 1868, in *Governors' Papers William W. Holden, 1868-1870,* Box 214, folder December 23-31, 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.

Andy Brinsfield.[66] The civil officers who were meant to deal with these outrages were also in danger from the Klan. The Klan threatened them in their homes at night.[67] The Klan, in Caswell County, as well as other counties across the state, made it so that the government could not effectively rule or enforce the rule of law. They did this to entirely undermine the Republican government and suppress Black political and social organizing.

The Klan also directly targeted leaders of the Black community to stop their organizing and building of political power. In September of 1869, Robert Fitzgerald had to hide away with a friend from the "Ku Klux who… [had] ill feelings towards [him] owing to [his] political opinions."[68] While he escaped the Klan's violence due to the community he had helped build, his story still demonstrated the Klan's direct violence against political and community leaders.

Wyatt Outlaw, himself, was a significant target of the Klan due to his centrality in the Black Community and the local Republican Party in Alamance County. On the night of February 26, 1870, the Klan broke into Outlaw's house, where he lived with his mother. They attacked both him and his mother before dragging him out of his house and taking him in front of the Graham courthouse.[69] There, the Klan lynched him, hung him from a tree, and cut open his mouth. They put a sign around him that said "beware you guilty, both white and [B]lack," emphasizing the racial and political motivation of the killing.[70] The Klan also killed a Black man named Puryear by tying rocks to his feet and throwing him into a mill pond for witnessing the

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[66] Ibid.
[67] Ibid.
[68] Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers #4177*, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
[69] Ibid., 128-130.
[70] Nelson, *Iron Confederacies,* 112-113.

lynching of Outlaw.[71] Some of the white community celebrated the Klan's murder of Outlaw. They saw it as the end of radical and Black rule over the state.[72]

Despite the danger and threats from the Klan, state senator Stephens remained in Caswell County and did his best to support and protect the Black community. In the Spring of 1870, he attended a meeting of the Conservative Party in the Yancyville courthouse. There, a prominent Conservative politician invited him to come downstairs to a clerk's room. Once in the room, he was faced with several white men and a noose. The Klan quickly locked the door behind him and put the noose around his neck. The Klan demanded that he "renounce his Republican principles," but Stephens refused, so the Klan hanged him by his neck until he was dead.[73] The Conservative Party and the Klan killed him for supporting freedpeople's rights. By killing leaders of the Black community and the Republican Party, the Klan, and by extension, the Conservative Party sought to suppress Black and Republican political organizing and power and reestablish white supremacist rule over the state.

Klan Violence happened across the Piedmont of North Carolina. While the organizations that called themselves or were known as the Klan were decentralized and unique to their respective counties, the Klan's goals and methods were unified. The Klan sought to reestablish white supremacist rule across North Carolina through terrorism and violence. They intimidated, stole, whipped, and lynched Black people and white Republicans to do this. The violence across the state showed a breakdown of the rule of law, but the two high-profile murders, of Outlaw and Stephens, both in or around a courthouse, were the final straw for the Republican government.

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[71] *61 Citizens Terrorized by Ku Klux,* 131-132.
[72] Rev. W. J. W. Crowder to Bettie A. Crowder, in *the Mebane Family Papers*, #3227, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
[73] Ibid., 173-175.

The government, due to this and the many other attacks on the black community in Alamance and Caswell Counties, moved to act in those counties.

Suppression of the Klan

Governor William W. Holden, in March of 1870, used the Shoffner Act to declare a state of insurrection in those two counties. The Schoffner Act was a law passed in January 1870 by Alamance senator T.M. Shoffner in response to the Klan violence across the state. It allowed the governor to declare a state of insurrection to deal with Klan violence and unrest.[74] The law confirmed the governor's power to declare insurrection and use militia to suppress insurrection in the state, but did not allow the governor to suspend Habeas Corpus, as that was against the North Carolina Constitution.[75] The law did little more than confirm existing powers of the governor, rather than expand their power. Nevertheless, Holden used the act as it was the only means he had at his disposal to suppress the Klan. In March of 1870, he declared that a state of insurrection led to the "Kirk-Holden War." This was the first major anti-Klan action taken by the State government. The so-called "war" saw no bloodshed, but the Conservative Party framed the anti-Klan action as a war to discredit the Republican government and gain popular support among the white population to regain control of the state.[76]

After declaring insurrection in Alamance and Caswell Counties, Governor Holden sent the militia under former Union officer George W. Kirk to suppress the Klan. He deployed the militia to Alamance and Caswell Counties in June of 1870.[77] The troops primarily came from Western North Carolina and started arresting suspected Klan members there, as well as one

[74] Jim D. Brisson, "'Civil Government Was Crumbling Around Me': The Kirk-Holden War of 1870," *The North Carolina Historical Review 88*, no. 2 (2011): 123–163, http://www.jstor.org/stable/23523540, 134; Allen W. Trelease, *White Terror: the Ku Klux Klan Conspiracy and Southern Reconstruction*, (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1995), 209-210.
[75] Trelease, *White Terror,* 209-210.
[76] Ibid., 124, 126.
[77] Ibid., 142-143, 144.

high-profile arrest in Orange County, which, unlike Alamance and Caswell Counties, Holden did not declare in a state of insurrection, despite the Klan violence in the county.[78] Nevertheless, troops under Kirk went into Orange and arrested Josiah Turner, a prominent Conservative figure, a newspaper editor from Orange County, and a former president of the NCRR Company. He raged against Holden and Kirk's suppression of the Klan while downplaying the Klan violence that led to Holden's use of the Schoffner Act.[79] He, like many other Conservatives, also claimed that the soldiers tortured prisoners and suppressed the Conservative vote, even claiming that this was Holden's "reign of terror."[80]

Turner's arrest further galvanized support for the Conservative Party in the state. Due to the Klan violence and the failure of civil courts to effectively hold Klansmen accountable, Holden suspended Habeas Corpus, despite the Schoffner Act not allowing him to do this. This enraged Conservative media.[81] Holden understood that the civil authorities had failed to suppress the Klan. Civil authorities were either too scared of or worked with the Klan, and thus, Holden saw North Carolina in a state of civil war. He framed his suspension of Habeas Corpus as a wartime necessity to suppress a rebellion.[82] Nevertheless, even though the state government suspended Habeas Corpus, most of the Klan men were taken before a judge and released before the end of the summer, after the initial arrest.[83] However, conservative media exaggerated Governor Holden's use of force while downplaying the rampant Klan violence, and the

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[78] Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers #4177*, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill; Brisson, "'Civil Government Was Crumbling Around Me,'" 146, 149.
[79] Brisson, "'Civil Government Was Crumbling Around Me,'" 146-148.
[80] Brisson, "'Civil Government Was Crumbling Around Me,'" 146-147; William W. Holden, *Argument in the impeachment trial of W.W. Holden, governor of North Carolina: full stenographic reports revised and corrected,* (Raleigh: J.H. Moore), https://digital.ncdcr.gov/Documents/Detail/argument-in-the-impeachment-trial-of-w.w.-holden-governor-of-north-carolina-full-stenographic-reports-revised-and-corrected/2148946.
[81] Brisson, "'Civil Government Was Crumbling Around Me,'" 148.
[82] Ibid. 135-136.
[83] Ibid., 151-152.

Conservative Party swept the election of 1870, gaining a majority in the legislative branch.[84] Almost immediately after taking control of the legislature, the Conservative Party called for the impeachment of Governor Holden.

The legislature tried Holden on eight charges. The articles of impeachment focused on Holden's use of the militia, his declaration of a state of insurrection, and his suspension of Habeas Corpus as unconstitutional and claimed that he was extending the Civil War in the state.[85] Holden defended his actions as constitutional and justified by highlighting the Klan violence in Caswell and Alamance Counties. He and his legal team brought many witnesses of the many Klan outrages against Black and white Republicans across the two counties to show that the counties were in a state of insurrection and rebellion.[86] However, with a Conservative majority in the legislative branch, Holden's fate was sealed.[87] By May of 1871, he was convicted on six of the eight charges against him and removed from office. He was the first governor to be impeached and removed from office, all because he attempted to suppress the Klan in Caswell and Alamance Counties. Following the impeachment and removal, Republicans held few seats, and Black representatives held even fewer, in the legislature.[88] The Klan and the Conservative Party had broken Republican rule over the state. With the Conservative Party in control of the legislature, it effectively ended any state support for Black civil and equal rights in the state. The state and federal government left the Black community of Piedmont and all of North Carolina to

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[84] Ibid., 155.
[85] William W. Holden, *Argument in the impeachment trial of W.W. Holden, governor of North Carolina: full stenographic reports revised and corrected,* (Raleigh: J.H. Moore), https://digital.ncdcr.gov/Documents/Detail/argument-in-the-impeachment-trial-of-w.w.-holden-governor-of-north-carolina-full-stenographic-reports-revised-and-corrected/2148946.
[86] Ibid.
[87] Ibid.
[88] Elizabeth Balanoff, "Negro Legislators in the North Carolina General Assembly, July, 1868-February, 1872," The *North Carolina Historical Review* 49, no. 1 (1972): 24-25, http://www.jstor.org/stable/23529002, 48, 55; Benjamin R. Justesen, "'The Class of '83': Black Watershed in the North Carolina General Assembly," *The North Carolina Historical Review* 86, no. 3 (2009): 282–308, http://www.jstor.org/stable/23523861, 283.

the mercy of the white supremacist rule in the state. The Klan violence and its suppression, the ascension of the Conservative Party, and the impeachment of Governor Holden are typically considered the end of Reconstruction in North Carolina.

Black Labor After Klan Violence

The Conservative resurgence and the end of Reconstruction did not end the transition of the Black community from enslaved laborers to free wage workers in Alamance and other counties across the North Carolina Piedmont. Many Black railroad laborers were formerly enslaved workers who had been hired out by their enslavers to work on the railroad.[89] They continued to work for the NCRR Company based in Alamance County. Many of these workers, before the Klan violence across the Piedmont, were part of the local Union Leagues and used it to push for political and social rights.[90] However, with the Klan murdering and intimidating the leaders of the Union Leagues and the Black community, political organizing dried up.[91] They no longer had an organization to push for their rights and fight against the oppressive white supremacist system. Furthermore, with the Conservative Party taking control of the government, the government no longer protected Black people's rights. Instead, Black railroad workers turned to carving out a living and surviving within the system. To do this, some Black workers relied on their railroad wages to support their families.

After the US Civil War, the South was very cash-poor, leading to heavy reliance on credit and the lack of cash wages for many tenant farmers. A majority of formerly enslaved people worked as tenant farmers and did not receive cash wages. They also lacked land and relied on credit from merchants.[92] This created economic dependence on the white community. Unlike

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[89] Keri Petersen "The North Carolina Railroad, industrial slavery, and the economic development of North Carolina"
[90] Nelson, *Iron Confederacies,* 103-105
[91] Ibid., 112-113.
[92] Holt, *Making Freedom Pay,* 28-29.

tenant farmers, railroad workers were paid in cash, which gave them unique economic independence and opportunities.

Despite the economic independence, the lives of Black workers after the Klan violence are heavily obscured in the archives, with little to no writing from the Black community itself due to high illiteracy rates and systemic racism in record keeping.[93] To understand the Piedmont during this time period, historians are often limited to records created by white people, such as the NCRR Company payroll records and census data. These records allow a glimpse into the lives of Black workers in Alamance and other North Carolina Piedmont Counties.

Despite earlier attempts by NCRR President Turner to root out Black and Republican aligned workers, many Black men made up the NCRR workforce.[94] Of the workers that I positively identified in the census records, 24 were Black and 25 were white.[95] White bosses and census takers primarily called Black workers "hands" or "laborers" in the payroll and census records, hinting at the belief that they were unskilled laborers.[96] Of these Black workers, several of them held specialized jobs that involved more skilled labor.[97] On average, higher-skilled workers on the NCRR in 1871 made between $.50 and $3.50 per day, with some of the laborers making around $100 per month.[98] Black workers typically made less money than their white

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[93] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource.
[94] Nelson, *Iron Confederacies,* 105.
[95] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource; North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina. To find out the race and profession of NCRR workers in the late 1860s and early 1870s, I investigated the payroll logs of the NCRR company in 1868 and cross referenced the names of over 500 workers' names with the federal census documents found on ancestry.com. This provided me with the names, races, occupations, pay, and property ownership information about each of the 50 workers that I found.
[96] Ibid.
[97] Ibid.
[98] North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.

peers, due to racism, job discrimination, and holding less skilled jobs, such as laborers.[99] These higher-skilled workers held a variety of jobs, including blacksmithing, tinning, building boilers, and carpentry. Most of the Black workers were relegated to work as apprentices or helpers.[100]

Many laborers on the NCRR supported themselves and their households on one income, suggesting some economic independence that many tenant farmers lacked. Jesse Summers, 30 years old, lived with his wife, Elma, and his two sons, Julius and Daniel. Jesse Summers worked as a blacksmith apprentice and made ninety cents per day.[101] Elma was not a domestic servant; instead, she was "keeping house."[102] This implies that she did not work for another, likely a white, family as a domestic servant, but rather kept her own house and labored for her family in her own house. Elma Summers likely did household labor for her family, such as keeping a garden, washing clothes, and taking care of their children. This labor was essential to the function of their family and a sign of self-determination, as she was no longer forced to work for a white family as a farm laborer or domestic servant. It also shows that Railroad workers were paid enough to support their own families, providing them with more independence from the white community. Despite being able to provide for his family, the family had no real estate or personal estate recorded in the census, meaning they likely rented a home.

Other skilled workers, such as boiler makers Wilson Ray and Sam Roberts, were also able to support themselves or their families on railroad wages. Wilson Ray, according to the census, lived alone.[103] This meant that he was able to rent a house on his own and support

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[99] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource; North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[100] North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[101] Ibid.
[102] Ibid.
[103] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource

himself on his railroad job. Further highlighting the economic independence of Black railroad workers is Sam Roberts. He lived with his likely wife, Letitia, who kept house, and their two children, Charles and George, who were both at home.[104] This again highlights the economic independence and stability of both Sam and Letitia Roberts, as Sam Roberts's labor was able to support his family on a single income, and Letitia was able to choose her labor and create a household for her husband and their children. Both men and their families, according to the census, also did not have any real or personal estate, which suggests that they rented their dwellings. Nevertheless, their ability to support themselves and a family on a single income indicates some economic independence and success in a cash-poor South.

Not all highly skilled workers could support their families and households on one income. Workers such as John Bates worked as a blacksmith for the NCRR but did not support his family on one income.[105] He lived with his family, consisting of Harriet Bates, who was 37 years old in 1870 and is likely John Bates' wife, his daughters, Francis, Minerva, and Sarah, and his son, John. The Bates family also lived with Harriet Bryan, Peter Benton, and Frank Hardle. Harriet Bates, Francis Bates, Harriet Bryan, and Frank Hardle all worked as domestic servants, while Peter Benton also worked on the NCRR, and Minerva and John Bates stayed at home as they were too young to work.[106] Unlike the other higher-skilled laborers, John Bates was not the sole provider for his family. Instead, his wife, children, and cohabitants also worked outside the home as domestic servants or also on the railroad. These point to a variety of lives and experiences that railroad workers experienced throughout the early 1870s. The Bates family also

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[104] Ibid.
[105] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource; North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[106] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource.

highlights more communal living, as they lived with other members of the Black working class who were not part of their immediate family.

While several Black workers held higher-skilled jobs, most of the Black workers held lower-skilled jobs as railroad hands or workers. It is expected that these higher-skilled laborers, even when paid less due to their race, were able to support their families on a single income; the same is true of many lower-skilled laborers. On average, lower-skilled workers or railroad hands made about $10 to $15 per month.[107] The NCRR company paid both white and Black railroad hands equally.[108] Railroad hands performed maintenance on the railroad, stations, and railroad cars.[109]

While they earned less money than the higher-skilled laborers, the hands and workers were still able to support their families on a single income or with the support of only a few family members. For instance, Abe (Abraham) Mebane was a wood presser who made about $15 per month.[110] Abraham Mebane had a wife, named Mary, who kept house, and a one-year-old son named Lincoln. Because the census states that Mary Mebane was "keeping house" instead of claiming to be a domestic servant, it can be inferred that she did not work for another family but labored in her own house.[111] This did not mean idleness for Mary Mebane, but domestic labor for herself and her family. She, like other freed women at the time, likely worked hard to create a home out of emancipation for her family. At the same time, it also meant that Abraham Mebane could support his family on one income. Other workers, such as Gaston Jeffers in Raleigh and Robt (Robert) Hayes in Charlotte, railroad laborers who earned $10 and $12 per month,

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[107] North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[108] Ibid.
[109] Railroad book.
[110] North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[111] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource.

respectively, were also able to support their families on one income. Gaston Jeffers supported his wife, Matilda, who kept house, his three children, William, James, and Cora, and likely his mother-in-law, or grandmother, Judy Feel.[112] Robert Hayes, earning slightly more than Gaston Jeffers, supported his wife, Catherine, also keeping house, and five children, Harriet, Ann, Mary, Leander, and Mary Cappo. Beyond just supporting his family, he had enough money to send his five children to school.[113] This highlights not only economic independence but also the significance of education for the Black community at this time. Robert chose to spend his limited resources to pay for the education of his children.

Education was essential to the Black community during and after Reconstruction. It was a place of empowerment and betterment for the Black community and one of the few places they had access to politics after Reconstruction. During Reconstruction, it was the site of ideological conflict with freed men and women using it to organize politically and socially, while the Klan attacked and attempted to suppress Black education.[114] While the Klan was successful in suppressing formal politics by killing, intimidating, or running off Black leaders and white allies, it failed to fully disrupt education as Black people, who could afford it, continued to send their children to school. Many Black railway and factory workers, such as Chas. (Charles) Albright of Guilford County, Nicolas Moody of Guilford County, Willis Jones of Yanceville, Joe Freedman of Charlotte, and many more, sent some of their family to school despite Klan violence against Black schools.[115] The number of Black workers who sent their children and families to school shows the significance of education for the Black community during and after Reconstruction.

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[112] Ibid.
[113] Ibid.
[114] Microfilm, in *the Fitzgerald Family Papers* #4177, Southern Historical Collection, Wilson Special Collections Library, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
[115] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource.

These workers, although they had some economic independence through their cash wages, rarely owned any real or personal property, as recorded in the federal census. This means that the workers had limited funds and chose to spend that money on education instead of saving to buy land or property. This was a form of agency and self-determination, as they made choices on how they spent their wages and chose what their children could do.

Not all Railroad hands were able to solely provide for their family. Many had to supplement their income with other members of their family doing farm or industrial labor. For instance, Thad. (Thadeus) Mayo, a railroad hand, who made about $12 a month and lived with his wife, Patience, who kept house, and his nine children, Josephine, Thomas, Sally Ann, George, Mary E, William, Lee, Henderson, and Samuel Reeves.[116] Of his nine children, three of them worked in a factory: Thomas, Sally Ann, and George.[117] The rest likely did household work for themselves to support the family. Another family, the Whites, also had to supplement their income with labor outside of the house. Willis White worked as a railroad hand making around $10 a month; his wife, Jane, kept house, his son Alexander worked as a laborer, while the rest of his children, Lizzie, Milley, Bud, Daniel, William, and Sonfont stayed at home.[118] Their labor outside of the home supplemented the family's income and allowed them to survive. Although it should also be noted that both of their wives did not have to work outside of the house, instead

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[116] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource; North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.
[117] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource.
[118] U.S. Census Bureau, *1870 Federal Census,* June 1, 1870, https://www.ancestrylibrary.com/search/collections/7163/records/22770746?tid=&pid=&queryId=3d97d699-f751-4153-891c-7ae1a8e7adf2&_phsrc=sVK401&_phstart=successSource; North Carolina Railroad Company, *Payroll Records,* Box 92, folder 1868, State Archives of North Carolina.

doing domestic labor inside the home to support their family, and only their children, who were of working age, labored outside of the home.[119]

While the workers had a variety of lives and experiences, they were united in the fact that they received cash wages in a cash-poor South, which allowed for economic independence and enabled them to support their families, often on a single income. Many of the workers were able to ensure that their wives only had to work in the house and not labor for other people, and often sent their children to school. Women, too, demonstrated self-determination by their ability and choice to work inside their homes for their own families instead of working for white families as domestic laborers or farmhands. While they were still poor and lacked property, they had a level of economic stability that many farm laborers lacked at this time. Through their labor, they carved out little bits of freedom and independence in a post-Klan violence Alamance and other counties along the railroad.

Conclusion

Klan violence was pervasive across North Carolina during Reconstruction. It sought to undermine the rule of law and Black people's social and political organization. Through disrupting Black organizing and undermining the rule of law, the Klan made the state ungoverned by the Republican Party, which led to the Conservatives taking back power. Despite Republicans losing power in the state, railroad workers, through their cash wages, carved out some freedom. This highlights the nuances of Reconstruction in the North Carolina Piedmont. Not all freed people worked in agriculture; instead, many continued to work on the railroad for cash wages. Cash wages allowed for greater freedom and economic prosperity in the face of white supremacist violence and the return of Conservative rule over the state. Nevertheless, Klan

[119] Hahn, *Nation Under our Feet;* Hunter, *Making Freedom Pay.*

violence and Conservative rule over the state reduced their political power and forced them to find ways to survive and create their own freedom in a hostile white supremacist system, like many Black people in the South following the end of Reconstruction. Their cash wages made this easier, but they still faced great hardship and oppression at the hands of the white supremacist system.

Through understanding Black labor on the railroad in North Carolina, we gain a clearer picture of how the South shifted from slavery to free wage labor and industrialization. It highlights the drastic shift towards free wage labor across the South after the abolition of slavery and how Black people leveraged their new wages to create freedom out of emancipation in the face of white supremacist violence. Railroad labor further contextualizes Southern industrialization following Reconstruction and its reliance on Black labor to build the new, more industrial South.

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